

March 2005 release of final serum dioxin report health officials ignore the ESR 2005 recommended study of exposed Paritutu families and announce the new focus will be on mainly male IWD workers.



Friday, March 11, 2005 TARANAKI

NATION/REGION

Past IWD workers new focus of dioxin study

By JAYNE HULBERT

THE health of hundreds of former Ivon Watkins-Dow workers will be investigated and some will be sampled for dioxin.

The move comes as a second round of blood tests has confirmed that people living near the Paritutu plant between 1962 and 1987 – when IWD produced the weed killer 2,4,5-T – have high levels of potentially cancer-causing dioxin in their bodies.

Levels of dioxin in the 52 people tested ranged from no higher than the New Zealand average, to 15 times higher and exposure came from breathing fumes from IWD as well as eating home-grown leafy vegetables and exposed fruit – like apples or grapes.

The tests were done by the Institute of Environmental Sciences and Research for the Health Ministry. Results of the second blood tests were released in New Plymouth yesterday.

Occupational Safety and Health spokesman Mike Cosman said an Otago University study would now look at the health of former IWD staff who worked at the plant during the production of 2,4,5-T.

While the number of deaths of former workers had already been investigated, this research would look at non-fatal health effects, Mr Cosman said.

"It would look at their health defects to find out their history and how long they worked at the plant. Then there is going to be some sampling of dioxin levels in those workers," Mr Cosman said.

About 1600 people had worked there during that period and they were currently being located.

Director of Public Health Mark Jacobs said yesterday's final results were from 52 people who had lived near

the plant. "It confirms the findings of the interim report, released in September last year, which found that residents who had lived very near to the plant for at least 15 years between 1962 and 1987 were more likely to have higher levels of dioxin than other New Zealanders," Dr Jacobs said.

He said the study deliberately concentrated on people most exposed to dioxins.

However, it did not determine whether health effects had occurred in this group of people.

"I have considerable sympathy for those people whose tests showed an elevated level of dioxin. I realise it is very worrying to get results like these without a clear indication of what they might mean for each person."

"It's a concern that people were exposed to this level. What we don't know is what that means for their future health."

Dr Jacobs said anyone who lived in Paritutu now, or in the suburb after 1987, had not been exposed to dioxins like those in the study.

"It's as safe as anywhere else in New Zealand."

Everyone who had participated in the studies was given vouchers to see a GP for free.

Ray Kennedy (90), who lived in Paritutu for 50 years, said he was told by officials yesterday that his dioxin levels were six times the New Zealand average.

But he did not think his health had been badly affected by the dioxin. "I've had cancer but I'm 90 and I'm still going. And I get around quite well for 90."

He attended the Ministry of Health briefing for the community, but most of the information he could not hear because he is deaf.

Ministry public health expert



DIOXIN DATA: Health officials (from left) Mike Cosman, Mark Jacobs, Deborah Read and Jonathan Coakley at a media conference in New Plymouth yesterday to release the final Paritutu dioxin report.

Photo: NIC GIBSON

Deborah Read said the levels of dioxin in study participants were significantly elevated. The average TCDD, a dioxin, for both groups was 6.5 picograms (pg/g) per gram of body fat, almost four times higher than the New Zealand average of 1.7 pg/g.

She said those residents with the highest dioxin levels had lived 1km east and 400m south of the plant for more than 15 years during the time 2,4,5-T was manufactured there.

Those elevated levels could cause up to three extra deaths from cancer in every one hundred people, Dr Read said. She said a study looking at the incidence of four rare cancers through out New Plymouth – lymphocytic leukaemia, soft tissue sarcoma, Hodgkin's disease and non-Hodgkin's lymphoma – which had been linked with historical dioxin exposure would be completed in June.

A second study looking at birth defect trends over time in New Plymouth compared with the rest of New Zealand, was also being done.

Dr Jacobs said the ministry would work with the Taranaki District Health Board to identify particular health needs within the Paritutu community.

He said at this stage legal advice had told them there were no grounds for legal action against IWD.

Green MP Sue Kedgley said the Government had to move quickly to help those affected by dioxin.

"This is a serious public health concern."

"In light of the latest results, the Government must stop procrastinating and provide medical and other assistance to residents who lived near the IWD plant," Ms Kedgley said.

She called for free annual medical check-ups for all affected residents.

Wear beanies to record

By KIM SCHW

BAD weather of a body belt tourist who Taranaki's sur 80th birthday. The man, Harold Henry living in Mary Police were a name, after Commissioner Mr Vernon, been heard reported mis evening. The found a body Point.

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Oakura home sells for \$1.35m

By KRYSTI WETTON



home, on Messenger Terrace, has been sold Photo: TREVOR READ

AN Oakura beachfront property has sold for \$1.35 million.

The Messenger Terrace house sold at auction last night for what is believed to be a record price for an Oakura home.

It was owned by Paul and Wendy Askew, who have bought another property in the town.

Robert Angus Real Estate sales consultant Clive Saleman said about 200 people turned up to the auction, which attracted three bidders.

The bidding started at \$1 million and quickly reached \$1.35 million.

The three-bedroom home, on freehold land, was sold to an American.

"It came here in 1986 to wind surf and has been coming back every year since," Mr Saleman said.

The Askews bought the property at 37 Messenger Terrace five years ago and converted the cottage into a modern home.

It overlooks Oakura beach and has unobstructed sea views.

"It's one of the more substantial homes on the beachfront," Mr Saleman

said. He said the Askews were happy with the sale.

The crowd enjoyed watching the property sell under the hammer, he said.

"They all clapped."

The home is the second on Taranaki's coast to sell for more than \$1 million in the past two weeks.

A record price was paid by tender for a New Plymouth house last week.

It is understood the Hine St property sold for \$1.5 million.

"The market is moving and growing," Mr Saleman said.

Massey CPHR applied for \$1.1 million of HRC funding to replicate the Dow funded Otago University study of primarily post 1969 ex IWD workers exposed after vacuums reduced reactor temperatures.

Massey CPHR and MoH officials also held an international dioxin forum at which Professor Allan Smith (Berkley & CPHR) dismissed the ESR 2005 recommended Paritutu family health study stating exposures were too low warrant it and Dr Deborah Read from the MoH said residents could not be studied as utility records had been destroyed in a fire. This claim is absurd as archived electoral rolls, property titles and phone books were readily available.

The new study, aims

1. To measure the **current dioxin levels** in the blood of the study participants

re-analyse the whole cohort using this exposure information
2. To determine whether dioxin levels are associated with **adverse health effects and reproductive outcomes**
3. To study effects of dioxin at the **cellular level**

RESEARCH GRANTS

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Dr Andrea 't Mannetje, Professor Neil Pearce, Dr Barry Borman, Dr Evan Dryson, Dr Chris Walls, Dr David J McLean, Dr Jefferson R Fowles, Ms Tania Slater, Dr David Phillips, Associate Professor Manolis Kogevinas, Professor Pier Bertazzi, Dr Patrick O'Connor

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Dioxin exposure levels and health effects in phenoxy herbicide production workers, 36 months, \$1,111,036